ORIONA ORGANIZATION

Official Organization Profile

Organization Type: Refugee-Led, Community Based Organization
Primary Location: Kakuma Refugee Camp & Urban Kenya
Operational Scope: Kenya (National Expansion Underway)
Profile Updated: April 2026

1. EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

ORIONA is a refugee-led, youth-driven organization purpose-built to transform how displaced people survive, grow, and integrate into society. Originally rooted in Kakuma Refugee Camp, ORIONA has expanded its reach to urban Kenya and is rapidly evolving into a multi-sector empowerment system that goes far beyond traditional humanitarian aid.

In a single defining statement:

"ORIONA is a bridge between vulnerability and independence."

ORIONA connects refugees to skills, jobs, mental strength, community and opportunity. Its transformative journey charts a clear path: from displacement → to dignity → to self-reliance → to leadership.

2. ORGANIZATIONAL SNAPSHOT

Full Name	ORIONA Organization
Type	Refugee-Led, Youth-Driven Non-Governmental Organization
Founded	Community-initiated; currently in active growth phase
Headquarters	Kakuma Refugee Camp, Turkana County, Kenya
Operational Areas	Kakuma Refugee Camp; Urban Kenya (Nairobi & beyond)
Target Beneficiaries	Refugee youth, urban refugees and displaced young people
Operational Model	Hybrid: volunteer-led with community and partner support

Strategic Vision	National refugee empowerment platform in Kenya
Partnerships	Actively seeking NGOs, employers, institutions, and donors
Online Presence	Listed on Idealist; expanding digital footprint

3. MISSION, VISION & VALUES

Mission

To empower refugee youth through integrated skills development, mental health support, economic inclusion and community engagement — enabling them to rebuild their lives with dignity, purpose and independence.

Vision

A Kenya where every refugee youth has the tools, opportunities, and networks to become a self-reliant, contributing member of society — and where displacement no longer defines a person's potential.

Core Values

- Dignity First — Every refugee is a human being with potential, not just a recipient of aid.
- Self-Reliance — ORIONA builds independence, not dependency.
- Community-Centered — Solutions emerge from within the community.
- Holistic Empowerment — Addressing mental, economic, social, and educational needs together.
- Inclusivity — Serving camp-based and urban refugees equally.
- Accountability — Transparent, impact-driven operations.

4. CORE IDENTITY & ORGANIZATIONAL CHARACTER

ORIONA is not a conventional NGO. It has been designed from the ground up by and for refugees — people with lived experience of displacement, crisis, and resilience. This gives ORIONA a credibility, cultural sensitivity and practical relevance that external organizations often struggle to replicate.

ORIONA occupies four defining roles simultaneously:

- A Refugee-Led Organization: Leadership, ideas, and energy come from within the refugee community, making ORIONA inherently authentic and trusted.
- A Social and Economic Development Hub: It creates real economic value through skills training, job connections, and income generation — not just awareness campaigns.

- A Networking Platform: ORIONA actively builds relationships between refugees, employers, communities, NGOs and institutions to open practical doors.
- A Practical Empowerment System: ORIONA focuses on outcomes — income earned, jobs secured, minds healed, leaders developed — not just activities conducted.

5. PROGRAMS & SERVICES (COMPLETE ECOSYSTEM)

ORIONA operates an integrated ecosystem of seven interconnected programs, each addressing a critical gap in refugee empowerment:

Program 1: Livelihood & Employment

ORIONA's most impactful pillar directly tackles the single greatest challenge facing refugees: the lack of sustainable income.

- Vocational skills training in masonry, hairdressing, mechanics, tailoring and service-based jobs
- Job placement and referrals to local employers and clients
- Connection to small business opportunities and self-employment pathways
- Special focus on urban refugees in Kenya — a population often overlooked by mainstream programs
- End-to-end pipeline: training → skills assessment → placement → income

Program 2: Skills Development & Vocational Training

ORIONA's philosophy is clear: if a skill does not lead to income, it is not enough.

- Hands-on, practical vocational training across multiple trades
- Business basics — financial literacy, income management and entrepreneurship fundamentals
- Digital and creative skills development (where resources allow)
- Training methodology anchored in real-world application, not classroom theory alone

Program 3: Mental Health & Psychosocial Support

Recognizing that sustainable empowerment begins with mental wellbeing, ORIONA has made psychosocial support a foundational pillar. As the organization's own philosophy states: "You cannot build a future with a broken mind."

- Peer counseling clubs operating in schools across the camp and urban settings
- Safe spaces where youth can openly share struggles without judgment
- Emotional support systems staffed by trained peer counselors
- Life skills and resilience training to build long-term coping capacity

Program 4: Creative Expression & Youth Engagement

ORIONA leverages creativity as a tool for healing, identity formation, and empowerment.

- Art, storytelling and media production programs
- Youth engagement activities that build community cohesion
- Creative expression as a vehicle for processing trauma and reclaiming voice and identity
- Outcomes: increased confidence, clearer sense of purpose, stronger self-advocacy

Program 5: Urban Refugee Integration Program

This is ORIONA's most strategically significant area of expansion. Urban refugees have freedom of movement but often lack structure, networks or support systems.

- Dedicated programming for refugees living in Nairobi, Nakuru, Eldoret, Kitale and other Kenyan cities
- Urban-specific job training and trade placement
- Economic integration support tailored to city contexts
- Bridging the gap between legal freedom and practical opportunity

Program 6: Community Engagement & Networking Hub

ORIONA functions as a connector, building bridges that reduce isolation and open real opportunities.

- Structured engagement between refugees and host communities
- Partnerships with businesses, NGOs and institutions
- Network-building events, referrals and collaborative initiatives
- Reduction of the "refugee isolation penalty" by integrating displaced youth into mainstream networks

Program 7: Education, Mentorship & Youth Development

ORIONA's goal is not just to develop workers — but to develop leaders.

- Structured mentorship programs pairing youth with role models and experienced guides
- Educational support and tutoring
- Life guidance and career pathway planning
- Alumni engagement: past beneficiaries become mentors and trainers

6. OPERATIONAL MODEL & TRANSFORMATION PIPELINE

ORIONA follows a clear, six-stage transformation pipeline that moves a refugee from initial vulnerability to community contributor:

1	**IDENTIFY**	Find vulnerable refugee youth in both camp and urban contexts through community outreach and partner referrals.
2	**STABILIZE**	Provide mental health support and create safe spaces that allow individuals to begin rebuilding emotional and psychological foundations.
3	**EQUIP**	Deliver hands-on vocational and practical income skills training that directly prepares participants for employment or self-employment.
4	**CONNECT**	Link trained individuals to jobs, markets, clients, businesses and relevant opportunities across Kenya.
5	**EMPOWER**	Support ongoing growth, confidence-building and the journey toward full economic independence and personal dignity.
6	**MULTIPLY**	Transform beneficiaries into mentors, trainers and community contributors who extend ORIONA's impact to the next generation.

This pipeline is not linear in isolation, it is cyclical. Each person who completes the journey becomes a resource for the next. ORIONA's model is self-reinforcing and community-powered.

7. IMPACT MODEL

ORIONA's theory of change operates in two connected chains:

Support → Skill → Income → Independence → Dignity
Dignity → Confidence → Leadership → Community Impact

The first chain addresses survival and material wellbeing. The second addresses transformation and legacy. Together, they produce not just economically stable individuals, but community leaders who give back.

8. WHAT MAKES ORIONA UNIQUE

A. Hybrid Empowerment Model

Most organizations specialize in one area. ORIONA combines mental health support, vocational skills training, job placement and community building into a single integrated system hence addressing the whole person, not just one dimension of need.

B. Authentic Refugee Leadership

ORIONA is led by refugees, designed for refugees and driven by lived experience. This creates deep community trust, cultural relevance and operational credibility that external organizations rarely achieve.

C. Dual-Context Operations

ORIONA operates simultaneously in refugee camp settings (Kakuma) and urban environments across Kenya, giving it rare versatility and reach in serving the full spectrum of Kenya's displaced population.

D. Anti-Dependency Architecture

ORIONA is deliberately designed to build self-reliance, not aid dependence. Every program is oriented toward income, independence and eventually, mentorship — creating a virtuous cycle rather than a cycle of support.

E. A Bridge System with Real Connections

ORIONA links refugees directly to real-world economic opportunities — jobs, clients, markets, and institutions. It is not a workshop provider; it is a connector. It closes the gap between training and income.

F. Youth-Led, Youth-Powered

Young people are not just the target beneficiaries , they are the implementers, the mentors and the future leaders of ORIONA itself. This embeds sustainability into the organization's DNA.

9. CURRENT REALITY & OPERATIONAL CONTEXT

Strengths

- Deep community trust and authentic refugee leadership
- A proven, comprehensive empowerment model across seven program areas
- Operational in both camp and urban settings
- Growing national profile and presence on key platforms (e.g., Idealist)
- Self-reinforcing model: graduates become contributors

Challenges

- Operates primarily through volunteers and community-sourced support, resource-intensive model
- Limited formal funding and institutional partnerships
- Expanding scope (urban refugee focus, economic integration, national scaling) requires funding, staffing and systems infrastructure
- Need for formalized monitoring, evaluation and impact reporting systems
- Competing with better-resourced international NGOs for donor attention despite superior community relevance

Current Priorities

- Securing strategic funding partnerships (foundations, bilateral donors, corporate CSR)
- Formalizing systems for program delivery, M&E and financial management
- Expanding urban refugee programming across Nairobi and other Kenyan cities
- Building employer and institutional partnerships to expand job placement
- Developing ORIONA's national brand and visibility

10. STRATEGIC VISION 2025–2030

ORIONA is on a deliberate trajectory toward becoming Kenya's leading refugee-led empowerment institution. The strategic vision is built around three pillars:

Pillar 1: National Refugee Empowerment Platform

ORIONA aims to scale its proven model across Kenya, establishing a presence in all major urban centers and refugee-hosting regions. The goal is to become the go-to organization for refugee economic empowerment in the country.

Pillar 2: Job Creation & Skills Ecosystem

ORIONA seeks to build a structured, demand-driven skills ecosystem that connects thousands of displaced youth to meaningful employment annually — creating measurable economic impact at scale.

Pillar 3: Model for Dignified Integration

ORIONA aims to demonstrate, document and export a replicable model for dignified refugee integration that can be adopted by other organizations and governments across East Africa and beyond.

Underpinning all three pillars is a commitment to keeping refugees at the center — not as aid recipients, but as architects of their own futures.

11. PARTNERSHIP & COLLABORATION OPPORTUNITIES

ORIONA actively welcomes partnerships with organizations and institutions that share its commitment to refugee dignity and economic inclusion. Areas of collaboration include:

Partnership Type	How We Can Work Together
Funding Partners	Grant support for program delivery, capacity building, and national scaling
Employer Partners	Job placement partnerships, apprenticeship programs, and internship opportunities for ORIONA graduates
NGO & UN Agencies	Referral networks, resource sharing, and co-implementation of integrated programs
Academic Institutions	Research partnerships, curriculum development, and credentialing of vocational training
Government Bodies	Policy engagement, legal support for urban refugees, and integration into national programs
Corporate Partners	CSR-funded training programs, skills sponsorship, and mentorship from private sector professionals
Media & Advocacy	Storytelling partnerships to amplify refugee voices and ORIONA's impact nationally and globally

12. CLOSING STATEMENT

ORIONA exists because the world's refugee crisis demands more than emergency response. It demands transformation. It demands that displaced people are seen not as problems to be managed, but as potential leaders waiting for the right opportunity.

ORIONA provides that opportunity. Through an integrated model of skills, mental health, economic inclusion, and community, ORIONA is turning displacement into direction — and vulnerability into vision.

Madul Gieth Mijak
Founder & Executive Director

Refugee-Led. Youth-Driven. Future-Focused.